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The City and the Stars: Politics and Alterity in Heidegger, Levinas and Blanchot

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The disaster: break with the star, break with every form of totality ... (Blanchot, Writing of the Disaster, 75)

In Plato's *Laws*, the Athenian stranger claims that there are two arguments in particular that foster the belief in the gods – the antiquity and divinity of the soul and the order of the heavens under the control of reason. No one who has contemplated the heavenly bodies carefully could suppose that celestial events happen by necessity rather than divine intention (*Laws* 966d). And indeed, the stranger maintains, no one can govern the *polis* who does not understand that the stars are steered by a divine will and exist in harmony with customs and law [*nomos*] (*Laws* 968). But what happens when this contemplation reveals neither the order of the soul nor the order of the heavens? What happens with the awareness that the disarray of the universe mirrors the disarray of the soul and it is no longer possible to harmonize the affairs of state according to a *nomos* that encompasses heaven and earth? The *polis* is cast adrift and our condition becomes, in John Caputo's word, *disastrous*, since the stars, *astres*, have fallen (*Against Ethics* 6). One can discern a desire to address this fallenness in the search for a lost moral unity, with the cohesion and solidarity of a society founded on hard work and co-operation. One can also find it in the attempt to revive a threatened spiritual unity by seeking, for example, a new embodiment of the early Christian community or the Muslim caliphate. But these attempts to re-harmonize individual, familial and societal responsibilities occur amidst the reign of efficiency and optimization, where the hegemony of the marketplace threatens to overturn old models of being-together. We cannot simply restore the missing *nomos*, placing the stars back in the sky. Indeed, we are no longer sure whether we know who 'we' are – consumers? citizens? subjects? As Caputo reflects, "It is not a question of knowing what to put in their place, but of just getting along without such a place, of conceding that things are just 'decentered', 'disseminated', 'disastered'. I would say that we are in a fix, except that even to say 'we' is to get into a still deeper fix. We are in the fix that we cannot say 'we' " (*Against Ethics* 6). How then can we endure this "disastronomic, disastrological, deconstructive setback" without the model of a stellar *nomos*, a stellar *logos* that could serve as the image of the loftiness of the law? (*Against Ethics* 6)

I

We are too late for the gods and too / Early for Being, Being's poem / Just begun, is man. // To head toward a star – this only. // To think is to confine yourself to a / single thought that one day stands / still like a star in the world's sky ("The Thinker as Poet," 4)

> In all the temples of the gods and in all sites of human habitation, this fire has its secure

> Heidegger would have us attend to the upsurge of the unhomely in this burning, that is, the

> it could also be that the Germans -- granted that they learn to use freely what is their own house" and establishment might be founded and build for the gods, one that the Greek temples ca

If it is impossible simply to reproduce Greece, to build temples to welcome the return of the

> the difference does not mediate after the fact by connecting world and things through a middle.

> In the sense in which Heidegger uses the word, **Dichtung** refers to a certain creative invention, the belonging of gods, mortals, world and earth, the fourfold in which a people can make a habitat.

II

Modern humanist man is a man in a State. Such a man is not merely vulgar; he is religion's true antagonist within the State of Israel itself [...]. It is obvious that Israel asserts itself in a different way. Like an empire on which the sun never sets, a religious history extends the size of its modest territory, even to the point where it absorbs a breath-taking past. But, contrary to national histories, this past, like an ancient civilization, places itself above nations, like a fixed star. And yet we are the living ladder that reaches up to the sky. ("Difficult Freedom" 260)

> Heidegger, with the whole of Western history, takes the relation with the Other as enacted in eminently the form in which the other becomes the same, by becoming mine (**Totality and Infinity**).

> For Heidegger, the Greeks build and thereby take possession of the earth, but the hearth remains.

> Heideggerian ontology, which subordinates the relationship with the Other to the relation with Being (48)

Levinas does not dispute the fact that the **polis** provides a certain unity to the relations of

> man is [...] the irruption of God within Being, or the bursting out of Being towards God; man

These dense sentences recapitulate the arguments of other texts, of the irruption into the order.

> The worry is induced by man by God's Infinity, which he can never contain, but which inspires

Why does Heidegger heed the poetic Muse rather than the word of God?

III

It is the dark disaster that brings the light. (Writing of the Disaster, 7)

Notes

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